

“Our vision is to be the travel stack of India”

Digi Yatra Foundation CEO Suresh Khadakbhavi on the technology behind the app, data security, and what’s in store

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Ask any frequent flyer in India which innovation has made their lives easier in recent times, and a majority is likely to mention Digi Yatra. For travellers on domestic flights, this service based on facial recognition eliminates the need to carry a copy of the boarding pass and show their ID at the airport. The organisation behind this service is Digi Yatra Foundation, helmed by CEO Suresh Khadakbhavi. An electronics & communication engineer by training who had a 15-year-plus stint with Bangalore International Airport Ltd, the 55-year-old says the service is still in the process of scaling up. In an interview with *Business*

Today’s Tech Editor Aayush Ailawadi, Khadakbhavi talks about the technology, privacy, the foundation’s structure, and the way ahead. Edited excerpts:

Q: Could you walk us through how Digi Yatra’s technology works and how it’s going to make things more seamless in the future?

A: Let me walk you through how we approached things when we were in the conceptual stages. We were thinking about the ideal passenger experience. We chose a scenario with a lady travelling with two young children. Kids can be unruly and imagine going through a manual process. This lady would have a trolley with bags; she may even be overwhelmed. On top of that, she has three travel documents and three ID cards to manage while walking and showing them all to get validated manually. Then she has to go through the process with her unruly kids. So, we designed the process around this persona.

In Digi Yatra, this lady can sit comfortably on the couch [at home], watching TV, and upload her ID card and that of her children’s (there’s a guardianship programme with rules) and finally share their boarding passes. Then, when she reaches the airport, she doesn’t have to show a single document. All she has to do is manage the kids and get them to go first, then she goes through. It’s a seamless process.